

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Mask ban emerges as key question

U.S. Border Patrol agents block a sidewalk while detaining a driver on Cicero Avenue while conducting an immigration operation Dec. 16 in Chicago. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



As Congress debates DHS funding, attire becomes flash point

By Lisa Mascaro
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Beyond the car windows being smashed, people tackled on city streets — or even a little child with a floppy bunny ears snowcap detained — the images of masked federal officers has become a flash point in the

Trump administration's immigration enforcement operations.

Not in recent U.S. memory has an American policing operation so consistently masked its thousands of officers from the public, a development that the Department of Homeland Security believes is important to safeguard employees from online harassment. But experts warn masking serves another purpose, inciting fear in communities, and risks shattering norms, accountability and trust between the police and its citizenry. Whether to ban the masks — or

allow the masking to continue — has emerged as a central question in the debate in Congress over funding Homeland Security ahead of Friday's midnight deadline, when it faces a partial agency shutdown.

"Humans read each others' faces — that's how we communicate," said Justin Smith, a former Colorado sheriff who is executive director and CEO of the National Sheriffs' Association.

"When you have a number of federal agents involved in these

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Four-year-old Josiah, with his grandmother Mariely Rivera, and great-grandfather, Carlos Rivera, visit the grave of his mother, Stephanie Gutiérrez, who was killed in 2022, at Fairview Memorial Park in Northlake, Jan. 15. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

'I FEEL LIKE THERE'S NO HELP'

Mother, family members question lack of charges in woman's 2022 shooting death

By Madeline Buckley | Chicago Tribune

The last time Mariely Rivera's daughter was in her house, she got in her mother's bed, laid down next to her and hugged her.

"Mom, I have made my decision," her daughter said. "I'm going to go back with him." Stephanie Gutiérrez was 20 — an adult — and all her mother could do was ask her to think about what she was doing. Gutiérrez shared a 1-year-old son with a partner who, according to Rivera, abused her.

Soon after, she was back with her boyfriend and texted a friend: "I'm so sad I swear I should've never (came) back sis."

Two days later, Gutiérrez was dead.

On Oct. 30, 2022, Chicago police officers were called to the 6800 block of West Grand Avenue on the city's North-

west Side, according to a police report. They found Gutiérrez unresponsive on a sidewalk suffering from a gunshot wound.

Detectives immediately noticed something wrong with the scene, according to police records. Even though Gutiérrez was found outside, it was clear the shooting happened inside the home.

Her boyfriend told detectives that Gutiérrez was hit by a bullet fired from a vehicle in a drive-by shooting, according to a summary of a police interview obtained by the Tribune. When detectives confronted him with evidence that pointed to an indoor shooting, the boyfriend asked for a lawyer.

More than three years have since passed. Heartbroken, Rivera has waited for charges that have not come.

She is not alone — though the Chicago Police Department

Turn to Death, Page 2

Parents push back to save schools

Archdiocese says time to mobilize has passed, decision final

By Hope Moses
Chicago Tribune

Since the Archdiocese of Chicago announced plans to shutter six schools at the end of the 2025-26 academic year, parents like Alicia Ferro, whose two children attend St. Jerome Catholic School in Armour Square, are scrambling to keep their school open.

But according to the archdiocese, the window to save their schools has passed — and its decision to close the schools is final. That leaves parents at St. Jerome and another school, Sts. Bruno and Richard School in Archer Heights, insisting they were blindsided.

At St. Jerome, some parents say they weren't told the school closure was on the horizon, before the archdiocese's Jan. 22 announcement. "Parents were never given the opportunity to get these efforts put into play," Ferro told the Tribune. "Now, you're just here scrambling — trying to figure out what you're going to do with your kids. They basically tied your hands."

The archdiocese, however, maintains that it fulfilled its responsibility to inform school officials of potential closures. While the archdiocese doesn't directly communicate with families, school and parish officials do, according to Scott McDonald, a spokesperson for the archdiocese.

Specifically, at St. Jerome, the archdiocese had been in discussions with the church parish and school administrators for more than a year, McDonald said in an email to the Tribune last week.

The archdiocese made school officials aware of the schools' dire situations at the start of this school year, said Greg Richmond,

Turn to Closings, Page 5

Aldermen voting to settle Guevara suits

City attorneys are recommending aldermen spend \$29.2 million to settle four wrongful conviction lawsuits tied to disgraced former Chicago police Detective Reynaldo Guevara. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Car dealers set to stock cheaper cars this year

As the economy enters a moment of uncertainty, attendees of the annual National Automobile Dealers Association convention in Las Vegas last week kept mentioning the intensifying need for affordable vehicles. **Business**

Yes, that was Chicago's Guerrero during halftime



In an image taken from video, Giancarlo Guerrero, left, the chief baton of Chicago's own Grant Park Music Festival, leads a group of string players during Bad Bunny's performance of the halftime show at the NFL Super Bowl Sunday in Santa Clara, California. **NFL**

The chief conductor of the Grant Park Music Festival performed with Bad Bunny

By Hannah Edgar
Chicago Tribune

Four minutes into Bad Bunny's half-time show during the Super Bowl on Sunday, the camera panned over two rows of grinning string players.

Leading them with graceful, sweeping beats and a sparkling hibiscus flower on his lapel? Giancarlo Guerrero, the chief conductor of Chicago's own Grant Park Music Festival, the free orchestra series that plays at Pritzker Pavilion every summer.

Speaking with the Tribune on Monday after the show, Guerrero said

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